

Aspire to compete, not extort



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“Net should be neutral. In an ideal world. But we don't live in an ideal world, do we now?”

In our lives, the Internet has emerged as the single biggest agent of change – whether it's the way we communicate with each other, get work done, socialize, or discover new ways of making our lives fulfilling and enriching. The Internet has become the fundamental building block of the Digital Era as we know it in the 21st century. In its relatively short existence, the Internet isn't just a spider web of interconnected computers any longer; it's a way of life. And its transformative power knows no bounds. We all have come to accept and adjust to this reality.

What we don't realize about the Internet readily is that it's largely thanks to its widespread ubiquity and virtually non-existent entry barrier that it's transformed into not just a powerful cultural force, but also an economic reality with extremely high stakes involved. Telecom companies responsible for laying the foundation of Internet connectivity charge us a basic cost of access to the Internet – this is fine. But with third-party data services and solutions being increasingly favoured over traditional telephony functions, Internet driven entities are attracting all the money while the telcos are allegedly kept hung out to dry. Telcos, therefore, want to introduce a DTH / cable TV model to Internet services, charging both ends of the wire – us and our Web destinations.

And that is essentially the bone of contention, in violation of the Internet's fundamental fabric – all data is equal, should be treated equally. Net should be neutral. In an ideal world. But we don't live in an ideal world, do we now?

In a country like ours, Internet connectivity can bring about a dramatic positive change in the lives of the lesser privileged sections of our society. Initiatives like Internet.org, which aim to offer popular sections of the Web virtually free of cost to those who've never even heard of the Internet, can drastically increase Internet penetration in the country's villages. But there's a danger here of consumers of such services mistakenly assuming the Internet to be nothing but the free bucket of services that they can feed on. Discrimination here may not be down to exact bits or bytes, but it's discrimination between competing services – serving one over the other. Why should a communications company decide what a consumer consumes? Isn't that against consumerism? Their (the consumer's) lack of knowledge can't be exploited in exchange of free

services – that's just morally wrong, anti-competitive and unfair trade.

If Net Neutrality ceases to exist, ISPs will hold all the power, and innovation will be stifled in the Age of the Internet Economy. And we all may be saying goodbye to the golden age of the Internet very soon. This is a disconcerting thought.

If ISPs were to come together and decide to raise prices for unilateral data access (just like OPEC sets international oil rates), we wouldn't have a choice but to pay more as consumers – just like people swear under their breath every time fuel prices rise, but they still pay more to get around. If Internet access is needed at all cost, you'll cough up the money no matter what. But would that satisfy corporate greed? And if power hungry ISPs and telcos are so worried about “over-the-top” services benefiting from a free ride on their Internet infrastructure, why can't they compete with them through their own substitute services?

I know it may not be realistic right now – building Facebook and Whatsapp clones – but that's essentially where we're heading towards in the future. Look how Netflix started as a video rental service, and now they don't just produce their own content to rival that of HBO's, it's also reshaping the TV industry as a whole. And it's doing so through the power of the Internet, keeping Comcast and other American ISPs at bay for now, shielded by Net Neutrality. But who's to say the next cycle of disruptive Internet services won't be created, owned and controlled by the ISPs? Holographic video calls developed by Airtel, or the mother of all online shopping portals developed by Vodafone, and so on. It's inevitable and bound to happen. Because the reverse is already happening, where an Internet company is trying to reshape the telecom sector (look up: Google Fi). As a consumer, this tussle and competition is just what the doctor ordered.

ISPs and telcos will have to reinvent, get their hands dirty and create the next wave of Internet services, or be satisfied with being as relevant as a paved road. Until the cracks appear... 

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